

No half-price pork chops

There was a time when farmers were too busy earning a living to worry about their public image.

There really wasn't a need for concern, anyway, because farmer and consumer transactions were

made directly with no middlemen separating the two. Later, as the journey of food from farm to urban table had some "detours" along the way, people still had memories of living on a

farm, or visits to country relatives, to keep them aware of the original source of their food supply.

The years passed and city consumers, separated from the farm by generations, began thinking of the supermarket as the origin of their food. And lawmakers, with little or no knowledge of agriculture, were making decisions which directly effected the lives of farmers. The independent, self-sufficient farmer who, a short time ago, was not concerned with public image, suddenly realized he needed the understanding and support of those not involved in his industry. He worked hard to build bridges

of understanding between farm and city—in personal contacts at mall promotions, fairs and farm tours, through speakers' bureau appearances before urban groups and in the schools. He took the time to get acquainted with his news media people and convince them that what was happening on the farm was NEWS—not just to farmers, but everyone.

Farmers have made great strides in promoting consumer understanding, but one area has them stumped. When farm prices go up, there always seems to be an excuse for retail food prices to rise—and this makes the headlines. Yet, when farm

prices decline, nobody cares—or even knows—except the farmer. It seems farm prices are related to food prices when they're on the rise, but not when they decline.

A case in point is the hog price situation. A year ago, hogs were selling for \$60 per hundred pounds. Recently, they've been below \$35 per hundred, almost a 50 percent drop. If consumers saw this drop in prices reflected in their pork chops—it would be news—but they don't. Whether farm prices are rising or falling doesn't really have that much effect on retail prices, because only 40 cents of the food dollar is put on at the farm level. The other 60 cents is added after the products leave the farm gate.

The farmer, with his ever-rising production costs, understands that the middlemen's costs are rising, too. What disturbs him is that it's the farm price that's always used as the reason for retail price increases. He thinks somebody else along the food production line ought to take a turn being the "heavy."

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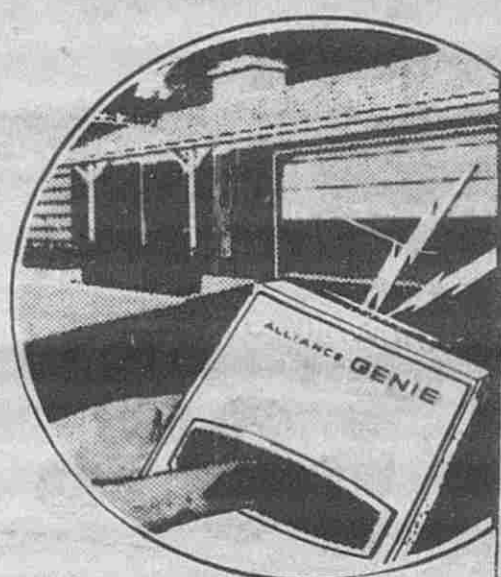
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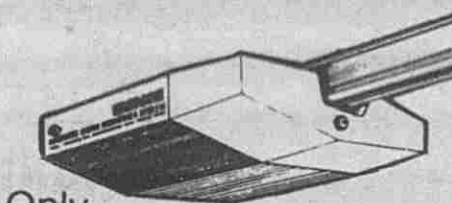
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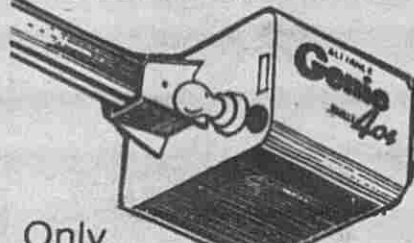
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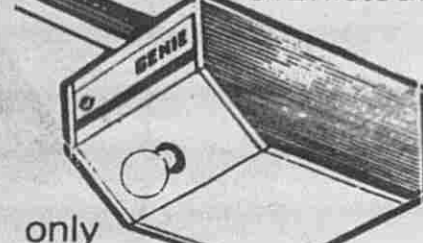
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